

The Gordian Knot

5ÈME • FICTION • LEGEND • 292 WORDS

NAME: _____ DATE: _____

An ancient legend from Phrygia, retold, and how Alexander the Great is said to have solved it.

The ancient kingdom of Phrygia was located in what is now modern Turkey. During a time in its history, Phrygia found itself without a king. Lacking a strong ruler, the Phrygians feared for their safety. They prayed for guidance and consulted the oracle at Telmissus for advice. To their relief, the oracle declared that the next man to enter the city with an ox cart would become king.

Meanwhile, the peasant Gordius was driving his ox cart towards the Phrygian capital. As he travelled, a golden eagle landed on his cart, which Gordius interpreted as a good omen. Unable to determine its meaning, he continued his journey, trusting that the meaning would be revealed.

When Gordius entered the capital, the people greeted him with acclaim; the priests crowned him their new king. The capital of Phrygia was renamed Gordium. Now Gordius had a son, Midas, who stepped forwards to honour his father, to reassure the Phrygians and to pay homage to Zeus, king of all gods. He dedicated the ox cart to Zeus and tied it with an intricate knot. The knot was so complicated that whoever untied it would rule all of Asia, predicted the oracle. From then on, the knot was called the Gordian knot.

As word spread about the knot and its promise, challengers arrived from everywhere to try to untie it. None succeeded. The Gordian knot held fast for generations until 333 BCE. That was when, according to legend, Alexander the Great came to Gordium, curious about the famed knot, which by now was weathered ever tighter. Unable to find its loose ends, Alexander dramatically cut the knot with a single stroke of his sword. He did go on to conquer much of Asia, thus fulfilling the prophecy.

A • ANNOTATE THE TEXT

1. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **PROBLEM**

Find the sentence that states the first problem the kingdom faces.

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2. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **CAUSE AND EFFECT**

Find the exact test the oracle sets for choosing the next king.

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3. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **FORESHADOWING**

Find the sign that hints Gordius is about to receive good fortune.

4. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **TURNING POINT**

Find the moment that finally solves the puzzle of the knot, generations after it was tied.

5. Underline in the passage the words that match this — **VOCABULARY**

Find the word that describes just how complicated the knot Midas ties really is.

B · READING QUESTIONS

6. What two problems does this legend follow, one after the other? **PROBLEM AND SOLUTION**

- (A) First choosing a king, then choosing which challenger should be allowed to try the knot
- (B) First a kingdom left with no king, then a knot that no one seems able to untie
- (C) First a peasant with no way to reach the city, then a king left with no heir behind him
- (D) First how best to honour the god Zeus, then how to reward whoever rules all of Asia

7. Why does the oracle's prophecy matter so much to everything that happens next? **CAUSE AND EFFECT**

- (A) It points the Phrygians to the one man among them who was the rightful king all along
- (B) It is the sign that makes Gordius trust the golden eagle and keep travelling to the city
- (C) It sets the test that turns an ordinary cart's arrival into proof of who should rule
- (D) It is the reason Midas later dedicates the ox cart to Zeus and ties his famous knot

8. "Midas... tied it with an intricate knot." What does "intricate" mean here? **VOCABULARY**

- (A) Beautifully decorated, as befits a gift offered to the god Zeus above
- (B) Loose enough that its ends could be found by any patient challenger
- (C) Extremely complicated, with many parts twisted tightly together
- (D) So large and heavy that lifting the cart by it took real strength

9. Why does the legend wait until 333 BCE, generations later, to introduce Alexander? **STRUCTURE**

- (A) To let the knot weather "ever tighter" so it becomes physically harder to undo
- (B) To show how long and how completely the knot had defeated everyone before him
- (C) To measure how many years Gordius's family kept ruling Phrygia after his death
- (D) To hint that only a foreign conqueror, never a Phrygian, could deal with the knot

10. What does cutting the knot instead of untying it suggest about Alexander? **INFERENCE**

- (A) He will solve a problem in a bold, unexpected way rather than the way everyone assumes
- (B) He cares most of all about being the very one who fulfils the oracle's promise of Asia
- (C) He thinks the knot is only a trick and not really worth any serious attempt
- (D) He is impatient, unwilling to spend real time working carefully at a hard problem

11. Which sentence best sums up what happens in this legend? **SUMMARY**

- (A) A prophecy makes the peasant Gordius king of Phrygia, his son ties an impossibly complex knot to honour Zeus, and generations later Alexander solves it by cutting it with his sword.
- (B) A golden eagle lands on the ox cart of a peasant travelling towards the Phrygian capital, and he takes it as a promising sign of the good fortune still to come.
- (C) Across the ancient world, the prophecies handed down by oracles were always trusted completely, and every last one of them was shown in the end to come true exactly as it had first been spoken.
- (D) Challengers travelled to Gordium from every direction to try their luck at untying the famous knot, and not a single one of them ever managed to succeed at it.

C · EVIDENCE VS CLAIM

12. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

"the next man to enter the city with an ox cart would become king"

- (A) The prophecy shows that the Phrygians already knew in advance which man would arrive by cart
- (B) The prophecy makes the ox cart the sacred object the Phrygians must guard
- (C) The prophecy turns an ordinary, everyday arrival into a clear sign of who should rule
- (D) The prophecy sets a contest that many men would race one another to win

13. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

"Unable to find its loose ends, Alexander dramatically cut the knot with a single stroke of his sword"

- (A) Alexander succeeds by changing the rules of the problem instead of playing by them
- (B) Alexander damages the offering by accident while searching it for its loose ends
- (C) Alexander proves the earlier challengers had simply not pulled hard enough on it
- (D) Alexander cuts the knot only after trying every ordinary method and failing at each

14. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

"The Gordian knot held fast for generations"

- (A) It shows the knot slowly loosened over the passing years until it was finally ready to undo
- (B) It shows the knot was guarded so that no one was allowed to attempt it
- (C) It shows how impossible the challenge had come to seem before Alexander arrived
- (D) It shows people had forgotten the knot until Alexander made it famous again

15. This quote is evidence that... **EVIDENCE VS CLAIM**

“He did go on to conquer much of Asia, thus fulfilling the prophecy”

- (A) It shows Alexander conquered Asia in order to earn the right to cut the knot
- (B) It confirms that the oracle’s much earlier prediction about the knot really did come true
- (C) It shows the prophecy had promised that Gordius, not Alexander, would be the one to rule Asia
- (D) It shows the conquest was a lucky accident with no link to the famous knot

D · BEST EXPLANATION

16. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

The oracle's prophecy is what makes Gordius's arrival meaningful.

“the next man to enter the city with an ox cart would become king”

- (A) Gordius happens to be driving his ox cart into the Phrygian capital at exactly this moment. This detail alone does not capture everything the passage actually says. Other parts of the text tell a rather different story from this one.
- (B) Without this exact rule from the oracle, an ordinary peasant arriving by cart would mean nothing; the prophecy is what transforms the event into proof he should be king.
- (C) This proves that anyone who owns an ox cart can eventually become king of Phrygia.
- (D) The oracle gives the Phrygians a rule to follow near the start of the legend.

17. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

The eagle landing on the cart foreshadows Gordius's good fortune.

“a golden eagle landed on his cart”

- (A) This proves that eagles were considered sacred, protected animals throughout ancient Phrygia. This detail alone does not capture everything the passage actually says. Other parts of the text tell a rather different story from this one.
- (B) Gordius reads the eagle as a good sign before he understands why; placing it here hints at coming fortune, well before the reader learns the reason.
- (C) A golden eagle lands on Gordius's ox cart while he is travelling towards the capital city.
- (D) An unusual animal appears in the story at this particular point in the journey.

18. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

Alexander's solution works by changing the problem, not solving it as intended.

“Alexander dramatically cut the knot with a single stroke of his sword”

- (A) This proves that Alexander was actually unable to solve the puzzle the knot presented at all.
- (B) Alexander does something dramatic and unexpected near the end of the legend.
- (C) Every challenger before him tried to find the knot's ends and untie it properly; Alexander instead removes the whole problem with one stroke, solving it by refusing the expected method.
- (D) Alexander arrives at Gordium and is curious about the famous, weathered knot everyone talks about. This detail alone does not capture everything the passage actually says. Other parts of the text tell a rather different story from this one.

19. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

The long gap before Alexander's arrival builds up the knot's reputation.

“The Gordian knot held fast for generations”

- (A) A long period of time passes at this particular point in the legend, before anything else happens. This detail alone does not capture everything the passage actually says. Other parts of the text tell a rather different story from this one.
- (B) This proves that nobody in Phrygia even remembered why the knot had originally been tied.
- (C) The Gordian knot stays tied for a very long time, until the year 333 BCE arrives at last.
- (D) Generations of failed attempts make the knot's reputation as unsolvable feel fully earned, so that Alexander's eventual solution feels all the more remarkable when it finally comes.

20. Which explanation proves the claim best? **BEST EXPLANATION**

CLAIM

The final line confirms the prophecy really did come true.

“He did go on to conquer much of Asia, thus fulfilling the prophecy”

- (A) By naming this as “fulfilling the prophecy”, the final line directly ties Alexander's real conquests back to Midas's oracle from generations earlier, closing the legend's whole arc.
- (B) This proves the prophecy was only ever really about military conquest, not about ruling wisely. This detail alone does not capture everything the passage actually says. Other parts of the text tell a rather different story from this one.
- (C) The legend ends by describing something that happens to Alexander after he leaves Gordium.
- (D) Alexander the Great goes on to conquer a large part of the continent of Asia after this event.

Answer key

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1. **1.** Underline: “Phrygia found itself without a king” — A kingdom with no king is the story’s first problem. Everything that follows, the prayer, the oracle, Gordius’s arrival, exists to solve it.
2. **2.** Underline: “the next man to enter the city with an ox cart would become king” — This single rule is what turns an ordinary peasant driving a cart into a king. Without this exact test, Gordius’s arrival would mean nothing at all.
3. **3.** Underline: “a golden eagle landed on his cart” — Gordius reads the eagle as “a good omen” before he knows why. The detail hints at what is coming, before the reader is told what it means.
4. **4.** Underline: “Alexander dramatically cut the knot with a single stroke of his sword” — Every challenger before Alexander tried and failed to untie the knot the expected way. His single stroke changes the whole problem, solving it by refusing to play by the old rules.
5. **5.** Underline: “tied it with an intricate knot” — “Intricate” means extremely complicated, with many parts tangled together. It sets up exactly why the knot becomes such a famous, unsolvable challenge.
6. **6. B** — Right. The oracle’s prophecy answers the first problem; Alexander’s sword answers the second, generations later.
7. **7. C** — Right. Without this rule, Gordius arriving by ox cart is just a peasant passing through, not a sign from the gods.
8. **8. C** — Right. This is exactly why the knot becomes such a legendary, seemingly unsolvable challenge.
9. **9. B** — Right. The long gap makes the knot’s reputation as unbeatable feel earned before Alexander arrives.
10. **10. A** — Right. Where others tried to untie the knot properly, Alexander simply changes the terms of the problem.
11. **11. A** — Right. It covers the whole shape of the legend, not just one part of it.
12. **12. C** — Right. Because of this rule, Gordius simply driving his cart into the city becomes a sign from the gods.
13. **13. A** — Right. He does not untie the knot; he removes the whole problem with one decisive stroke.
14. **14. C** — Right. Generations of failure make his eventual, unconventional solution feel all the more remarkable.
15. **15. B** — Right. The final line ties Alexander’s real conquests directly back to the oracle from generations before.
16. **16. B** — Strong. It explains precisely how the prophecy converts an ordinary event into something meaningful.
17. **17. B** — Strong. It connects the omen to the later reveal and explains the foreshadowing itself.
18. **18. C** — Strong. It contrasts his method with everyone else’s and explains why that makes it a real solution.
19. **19. D** — Strong. It links the passage of time directly to how impressive Alexander’s solution later feels.
20. **20. A** — Strong. It explains exactly how the ending connects back to the earlier prophecy about the knot.